EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Do Strange Misvot Make Sense?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:10

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 3 (Commandment and Prohibition), Chapter 10, questions 4 to 12

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 4 November 2024, on Zoom (the first shiur after the Sukkot break, the week of Parashat Lech Lecha)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where Essay 3 Sits

The Rabbi welcomed everyone back from the break to the **winter schedule**: 6 to 7 pm, hopefully mostly **in person** as well as on Zoom. Before starting Essay 4, the last chapter of Essay 3 had to be finished.

Essay	Theme
1	**The Creator**: the concept of a Creator at all
2	**The Jewish Creator**: Hashem's unity, anthropomorphism in the Torah, the ways we describe Hashem
3	**Revelation**: rational and revelatory mitzvot; prophecy, how a prophet is verified (Saadia's approach and the Rambam's), and false prophets; and, in Chapters 7 to 9, **abrogation**: can the Torah be changed, superseded or swapped?

Chapter 10. Since the essay is about revelation, and Tanach is the pinnacle of revelation, Saadia answers **twelve questions** people ask about whether the Torah is rational. They come from the 200 objections of **Chivi al-Balkhi**. Before the break we saw the first three: **why the Torah is not clear** and needs interpretation, and **numbers that seem to contradict**. Tonight, questions four to twelve, "some of them very interesting in terms of his understanding of the mitzvah vis-à-vis the other Rishonim."

Question 4: Sacrifices

Someone may be troubled by **the sacrifices**: that animals are slaughtered, and that we offer up their **blood and fat**. How is this fair to the animal? "Something which people have been asking for many years, but he was the first person to articulate this question. It's fascinating," eleven hundred years ago.

Slaughter in place of death

1. Hashem decreed that **every creature dies**.
2. Humans have **a fixed lifespan**. An animal's lifespan is **until it is slaughtered**. **Shechitah stands in place of death.**

3. Is slaughter **more painful** than dying naturally? **Only Hashem knows.** "I don't know if that's true or not."
4. **If it is true**, and if it can be **proven scientifically**, then the animals **will be compensated** for that pain. Nothing in the Torah indicates compensation for animals, but if it were proven, Saadia would have to concede it.

Why the blood and the fat?

The soul is sustained by the blood. When we see the blood sprinkled and the fat burnt, we say to ourselves that we will sin no more, **so that our own blood will not be spilt and our fat burnt** as we are seeing before us.

The Rabbi noted that this second idea is recorded by many Rishonim, notably **the Ramban** on the Torah: seeing it arouses **a feeling of guilt**, "really this should be happening to me," and so it becomes **a way of teshuvah**. The animal takes our place, and that brings us back to Hashem.

The Rambam against compensation for animals

"What's fascinating about this is that Saadia seems to be indicating a system of **compensation for animals**, which we don't find anywhere in Tanach or in our literature." The **Rambam** did not like it at all, and in the **Moreh Nevuchim** he referred to Saadia without naming him:

Our Torah deals only with human situations. Compensation for animals **has never been heard in our faith** from ancient times, and none of our Rabbis spoke of it. **One of the later Geonim** heard it from the Arab philosophers, **the Mu'tazilites**, thought it correct, and adopted it.

- **In Saadia's defence:** he never says categorically that animals are compensated, only that **if** slaughter were proven more painful, he would have to accept some compensation.
- **"But the Rambam is right."** And in the Rambam's philosophy it is completely alien: there is **no individual providence** (*hashgachah peratit*) **over animals**, only **general providence** (*hashgachah kelalit*) over the species. The Rabbi noted that the **Ramchal** in Derech Hashem, which the class had learned, says the same. "So this would make absolute nonsense for the Rambam."

Question 5: Why the Shechinah Among Humans and Not Angels?

The question is not why Hashem rests His Shechinah among humans; that is fine, He wants to give us the ability to build His presence. The question is why **among humans and not among the angels**.

"Simple answer. **Who told you the angels don't have the Shechinah among them?**" It is quite possible Hashem rests it among them many times more. Saadia brings the verse:

אל נערץ בסוד קדשים רבה, ונורא על כל סביביו

God is revered in the great council of the holy ones, and awesome over all who surround Him. (Tehillim 89:8)

"All who surround Him" are the angels. So it is not a question.

Question 6: Does Hashem Need a Mishkan?

Someone is astonished by **building a Mishkan for God**: people playing music for Him, baking for Him, offering fragrant incense, flour, oil, wine and *bikkurim*. **Does Hashem need all this?**

"We've had this many times, but the revolutionary thing is that Saadia is the first one saying something of this kind."

All of these are ways of service, not things God needs. Reason tells you Hashem needs nothing; rather, **everything needs Him.**

- We serve Him with **the best humans have**, "at least in those days": meat, wine, salt, flour, frankincense, oil and sweet fruit. Bring a little, and Hashem repays far more.
- **Honour Hashem from your wealth, and your storehouses will be filled with plenty** (Mishlei 3).
- **Offer to God thanksgiving, pay your vows, and call on Me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you** (Tehillim 50).
- We honour Him in the Mishkan, **the place called the Shechinah's dwelling**, with gold, silver, precious stones, scarlet and fine linen, and Hashem compensates us by **revealing Himself** there: **ונעדתי שמה**, "I will meet with you there." There He hears our prayers.

By creating the Mishkan, we create a space where we can connect with the divine and develop the relationship. "Not, chas veshalom, that He needs it."

Question 7: Brit Milah

"Which is actually **this week's parashah**. And his answer is interesting."

How can a person **created by Hashem** be born **incomplete**, so that only by **cutting off** the foreskin does he become complete? Surely cutting something off makes you less perfect, not more.

Saadia: removing the extra

Something complete is something with nothing extra. Hashem created the foreskin as **an addition to the body**. We are born incomplete because we have **too much**, and removing it makes us complete.

The Rambam: weakening the limb

The Rambam (**Moreh Nevuchim 3:49**) rejects this, again without naming Saadia:

- **"Any person who thinks has a simple question":** how can natural things be imperfect, and become perfect only when we intervene? Surely nature is perfect and intervention makes it imperfect.
- It was also clear to the Rambam that the foreskin **has a benefit**, being a protection. So removing it cannot be perfecting an imperfection.
- **The real purpose:** to complete a deficiency **not in the body but in our character**. Milah **weakens the limb**, not so much that one cannot have children, but enough to subdue **excessive passion and desire**. It is symbolic of **restraining oneself**.
- **His proof**, as a doctor: circumcision weakens the organ and lessens enjoyment, "there's no doubt to me." And he brings the Hachamim: a woman who has had relations with an uncircumcised man finds it hard to separate from him.
- **Why Avraham first?** Because Avraham was **the epitome of modesty**. As we read this week, coming to Egypt he tells Sarah, **הנה נא ידעתי כי אשה יפת מראה את**, "**Behold, now** I know that you are beautiful." The Hachamim read it: only now, approaching a dangerous place, did he really look at her.

A Midrash for Saadia: the five foreskins

"In Saadia's defence, there is a Midrash which says exactly what Saadia says": **Midrash Tanchuma** on this week's parashah.

Hashem tells Avraham, **התהלך לפני והיה תמים**, "walk before Me and be complete." Avraham is astonished: if I circumcise myself I will be **deficient**! Hashem answers: **you think you are complete now? You are missing five things.** There are **five foreskins**:

Foreskin	Verse
The literal one	
The ear	"their ear is uncircumcised; they cannot listen"
The heart	"circumcise the foreskin of your heart" (Parashat Ekev)
The lips	"uncircumcised of lips"
The flesh	

And the gematria: **אברם** (Avram) is **243**, but a human has **248 limbs**. With the milah the five "foreskins" are removed, the letter **ה** is added, and **אברהם** is **248**. "Now you've got a proper ear, a proper tongue. Now you will become perfect."

Not all Midrashim are equal

"This is important to recognise." **Midrash Tanchuma is not a Midrash from the time of the Talmud.** Midrash Rabbah (Bereishit Rabbah, Shemot Rabbah, Vayikra Rabbah) comes from the Tanna'im and Amora'im. Tanchuma, like **Midrash Shocher Tov**, is much later: the Rabbi looked it up during the shiur and gave **somewhere between the 8th and 10th centuries**. So the Rambam was not bound by it. "It's a beautiful Midrash, it fits in beautifully, but it doesn't bother the Rambam."

"Do not be fooled by hearing the word *Midrash*. When you hear the word Midrash, you always have to understand **where the Midrash is from**."

From the class

- **Chaim** asked whether, with the metaphorical foreskins, removing them makes you **stronger**. The Rabbi: according to Saadia and the Tanchuma, **yes**, all of them make you better, more wholesome and more complete. That is exactly what the Rambam rejects for the physical milah: you bleed, you lose a protection.
- A participant suggested **hygiene**. "No one says that, and the Rishonim don't say that, but of course it's a benefit." Whether it was the reason for the mitzvah is debatable, but it could be added as a modern reason.

Question 8: The Red Heifer

The *parah adumah* **purifies the impure**, yet those who prepare and administer it, who must be pure to do so, **become impure**. "This whole essay is about the rationality of the Torah." The question is not how ashes purify. It is **how one thing can have opposite effects**.

Saadia: it is not outside our experience.

- **Fire** melts lead, yet **solidifies** milk.
- **Water** makes most things moist, yet apparently makes **the sycamore tree** drier. "If anyone can elaborate or explain this, I'll be glad to hear."
- **Food** is good when hungry and bad when full.
- **Medicine** is good when ill and bad when well.

The Rabbi was not convinced. In all these examples, **the substance is the same and the state of the person differs**. That is why food helps the hungry and harms the full. But if the ashes have the power to make the impure pure, why should they make the pure impure? "I don't fully appreciate this answer." The **Ibn Ezra** quotes Saadia with the example of **honey**, bad for some and good for others, "and sorry, I don't really think it's correct."

Question 9: Azazel

"Now we come to something which we dealt with recently, and this is fascinating. **Really fascinating.**" On Yom Kippur we read Acharei Mot: two goats, one offered in the Temple and one sent **to Azazel**. People think Azazel is **some kind of demon**. Are we offering sacrifices to demons, to other gods?

Saadia: Azazel is a place

No. Azazel is **the name of a place, a mountain**, like other names in Tanach ending in *el*. Sending the goat *la'azazel* simply tells you **where** it was sent. "What's the obvious question? They all have *el* in them, but Azazel is different." The Ibn Ezra raises the linguistic problems.

- **One goat** is offered in the Temple, atoning for **the Kohanim who serve there**.
- **The other** atones for **the people outside the Temple**, ordinary Israel, so it is sent to a nearby place called Azazel.
- **Why the lots?** People thought the lots were cast because the goats went **to two different deities**. No: both are sacrifices **to the same God**. The lots simply make clear which is for whom.

"This to me is the strangest thing, casting lots. It sounds very demonic." And of Saadia's answer: "Not a very convincing answer."

The Gemara and Rashi: a fierce cliff

The **Gemara** (Yoma) reads **עזאזל** as **עז וקשה**, strong and hard. **Rashi** on the Torah: **הר עז וקשה, צוק גבוה**, a formidable mountain, a high cliff, sheer, not a slope. The Rishonim did not take it as the simple meaning, since the word *har*, mountain, is missing.

The Ibn Ezra's hint and the Ramban's revelation

The **Ibn Ezra** brings Saadia's view and the difficulties with it, then gives no answer of his own, only a hint: **"I will reveal to you a little of the secret by a hint: when you are thirty-three, you will understand it."**

"Ibn Ezra does this sometimes, a few places in the Torah, when he wants to tell you something too controversial to say outright." (The Rabbi added that he should one day do a series on the Ibn Ezra's hints, "it's unbelievable the kinds of things he was referring to," and what scholars have debated about each.)

The Ramban quotes him:

ורבי אברהם נאמן רוח מכסה דבר, ואני הרכיל מגלה סודו

Rabbi Avraham, being of faithful spirit, conceals the matter; and I, **the talebearer**, will reveal his secret.

The Ramban brings Midrashim: we give **Samael**, the forces of evil, **a bribe**, so that he will not interfere with the offering to Hashem in the Temple. Samael sees it and says: this nation is like the angels. As the angels are barefoot, they are barefoot; as the angels do not eat or drink, they do not eat or drink on Yom Kippur.

The thirty-three. The Rabbi counted it out on the screen: **count 33 verses from the first mention of Azazel** in Acharei Mot. The 33rd verse, already past the Yom Kippur service, forbids offering sacrifices outside the Temple:

ולא יזבחו עוד את זבחיהם לשעירם

They shall no longer offer their sacrifices **to the goat-demons**. (Vayikra 17:7)

That is the Ibn Ezra's hint: once you are past 33 verses, you will understand what Azazel is. For the Ibn Ezra and the Ramban, one offering goes to Hashem, and so that **the *se'irim*, the forces of evil, do not hijack it**, Azazel is given "his taste."

	Azazel is...
Saadia	**A place** near the Temple; both goats are for Hashem; the lots only assign them
The Gemara and Rashi	**A hard, sheer cliff**
The Ibn Ezra (hinted) and the Ramban	A portion given to **the forces of evil**, a "bribe" to Samael

"Saadia is very monotheistic. Let me rephrase that, not that the others aren't." But Saadia, and the Rambam, who "would never, ever accept an interpretation like this," cannot accept offering anything to another force, so for Saadia it must be a place. "How to understand the Ibn Ezra and the Ramban is really difficult, to be honest. But that's perhaps a discussion for another time."

Philippe asked where this place was. The Rabbi explained that for Saadia it is a cliff just outside, very near the Temple, from which the goat was thrown down into the wilderness, and it was called Azazel.

Question 10: The Eglah Arufah

When a murdered person is found outside a town and **no one knows who killed him**, the elders take a calf, break its neck by a stream, and that ground may never be worked again. The Torah says **no one knows who struck him**. So why do **the elders, who did no sin**, bring this offering?

	The purpose of the *eglah arufah*
Saadia	**Atonement for the elders.** One can be punished for **passivity** as well as action. Had there been more security guards and officers, they would have known who committed this murder. They lose the calf and the use of the field
The Rambam	"Much simpler, and classic Rambam." It is a **strange public act**: measuring to the nearest town, the elders, the calf, the barren valley. **People will talk about it**, and whoever knows the murderer, or something about him, will come forward. As soon as the killer is found, the procedure stops. "There's no atonement here"
The Abarbanel	**Atonement for the people, and more.** A calf that has never borne young or been worked, whose potential is cut off, should **shock** us into remembering that **a human being with his whole life ahead of him** was killed. Why are we not shaken? It drives us to find the killer and to improve society so it never happens again

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Question 11: Why Is the People of God So Downtrodden?

The Jewish people, the nation of God, seem the most downtrodden. "Look at us nowadays: how much international pressure on Israel, how much Jews across the world are being persecuted." This, the Rabbi said, was **a common Christian argument**: you are always persecuted by us, so how can you be God's people?

Saadia's answer:

- If Hashem made us **always sovereign and in power**, the other religions would say **we only serve Hashem because life is good for us**, just as **the Satan said of Iyov**: he has everything, that is why he serves You.
- They would also excuse themselves: we do not serve God because we lack the Jews' luck.
- Instead **He lowered us and exiled us, and we did not give up our faith**, and so in the long run we are deserving of Hashem's justice and mercy.

לא נסוג אחור לבנו ותט אשורינו מני ארחך

Our heart has not turned back, nor have our steps strayed from Your path. (Tehillim 44:19)

Question 12: Why No Olam HaBa in the Torah?

"A huge question." Why does the Torah mention **only reward in this world** and never the World to Come?

"Great question. Two-line answer. What's going to be his answer?" Saadia: **I have written a whole essay on this, Essay 9**, and I will explain everything necessary there. End of Essay 3.

Summary: The Twelve Questions of Chapter 10

#	Question	Answer
1	The Torah is unclear	Intellect and tradition complete it (before the break)
2-3	Contradictory numbers	Reconciled (before the break)
4	Sacrifices, blood and fat	They awaken us to teshuvah; *if* shechitah is more painful, animals may be compensated (the Rambam rejects this)
5	Shechinah among humans, not angels	Who says not? Perhaps far more among the angels
6	Does Hashem need a Mishkan?	No; it is for us, to build the relationship
7	Milah	Saadia and the Tanchuma: removing the extra makes us complete. The Rambam: to weaken desire, a lesson in restraint
8	The red heifer	One thing can have opposite effects (the Rabbi was unconvinced)
9	Azazel	Saadia: a place. The Gemara and Rashi: a sheer cliff. The Ibn Ezra and the Ramban: a portion for the forces of evil
10	The *eglah arufah*	Saadia: atonement for the elders' negligence. The Rambam: publicity to catch the killer. The Abarbanel: shock us into fixing society
11	Israel's suffering	So no one can say we serve Hashem only because life is good
12	No Olam HaBa in the Torah	See Essay 9

Coming Up: Essay 4

- **Next week, same time:** Essay 4, on **free will**. A relatively short essay of six chapters.
- Saadia is **the first to ask the famous question of free will and Hashem's foreknowledge**, which comes in Chapters 3 and 4.
- He also discusses **the status of man in the universe**, and there will be **a big debate among the Rishonim** over whether man is indeed the centre of the universe.

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